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ARTICLE



Baby boomers' retirement decision and adaptation in Taiwan: older adult learners' experiences

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ABSTRACT

Baby boomers in Taiwan benefit from better health, economic conditions, and education in comparison to older generations. The participants in this study were older adult learners from the baby boom generation. This study aimed to examine their retirement decisions, adaptation, and learning processes. A qualitative research approach was employed in this study. Data were collected via semi-structured interviews. Thirty-one individuals, consisting of 15 men and 16 women aged 55–68 years, were interviewed. The research results showed that the interviewees' retirement decisions involved an awareness of retirement timing, and in addition, four approaches to retirement decisions were identified, namely, straightforward decision making, retirement planning, hesitancy, and involuntary retirement. Each decision approach would lead to various losses and gains. The background of baby boomers provided them with high adaptability and the motivation to learn and change. The retirement adaptation process presented goals related to health, learning, and contributions. Learning participation and service learning allowed the interviewed baby boomers to feel joy from learning, forget about their age, and maintain positive attitudes. The results of this study can provide workers engaged in the field of older adult education with a reference for the formulation of policies and projects related to retirement transition and learning.

Introduction

With the increase in average life span and population aging, retirement-related research has become an important issue in aged societies (Noone, Stephens, & Alpass, 2009). Many countries have established postponed retirement policies, however, the actual retirement age in many developed countries is under 65 years (Schreurs, Cuyper, van Emmerik, Notelaers, & de Witte, 2011). In 2016, the average retirement age in Taiwan was 58.6 years, with 56.0% of retired persons aged between 55 and 64, 23.6% aged between 45 and 54, and 19.4% aged 65 years or older (Executive Yuan, 2017).

The baby boom generation in Taiwan includes 5,444,662 people born between 1946–1964 and accounts for 23% of the population (Ministry of the Interior, 2018). The baby boomers in Taiwan were the first ethnic Chinese people to acquire comprehensive education, experience both autocracy and democracy, and move from poverty to prosperity. They also witnessed reforms in the retirement system (Wang & Lo, 2013). In comparison to older generations, baby boomers benefited from better health, economy, and human capital (Chen, Chuang, & Yang, 2015; Duberley, Carmichael, & Szmigin, 2014). However, early retirement is a common phenomenon among baby boomers, and most of them fail to plan well for retirement (Quine, Bemard, & Kendig, 2006).

The process of retirement decision and adaptation includes a consideration of appropriate retirement timing, retirement decision factors, and adaptation to post-retirement life (Atchley & Barusch, 2004). Retirement decisions and transitions trigger job- and role-related psychological and social changes and require adaptation to post-retirement life (Hartlapp & Schmid, 2008; Havighurst, 1972). This process is associated with losses and choices, the search for purpose, and the process of adaptation. Different models have been proposed for the process of retirement decision and adaptation, such as the model of selective optimization with compensation developed by Baltes and Baltes (1990). It is important to determine how, in the face of losses, older adults can age successfully by adapting to aging and life changes through learning (Duay & Bryan, 2008; Lee & Yeh, 2012; Ogunbameru & Asa, 2008; Russell, 2011).

A wealth of results has been generated from past studies on retirement transition. However, there is a lack of research on the relationship between retirement decisions and adaptation and learning. Therefore, the objective of this study was to examine retirement decisions, retirement adaptation, and learning in baby boomers in Taiwan.

Literature review

The transition from work to retirement is a process. Atchley and Barusch (2004) suggested that during the process of retirement decision and adaptation, an individual considers his or her retirement timing, factors influencing his or her retirement decision, and adaptation to post-retirement life. This process was described in the model of selective optimization with compensation (SOC) proposed by Baltes and Baltes (1990). SOC consists of three interrelated components. The first component is selection, which refers to goal setting; the second component is optimization, which concerns resource acquisition; and the final component is compensation, which relates to the acquisition of alternative skills or utilization of alternative methods when access to resources is reduced or cut off (Baltes & Baltes, 1990). The model considered gains and losses and shifted focus toward the ways to reach goals while experiencing losses during aging (Baltes & Baltes, 1990; Baltes & Carstensen, 2008).

In the process of selection when making a retirement decision, individuals consider retirement timing. Atchley and Barusch (2004) and Phua and McNally (2008) indicated that individuals have a vague idea of retirement, cherish illusions or worry about retirement because they think of it as something in the distant future. Retirement decisions involve multiple factors, including policies, the economy, socio-economic positions, years of service, and personal experiences and skills (Topa, Moriano, Depolo, Alcover, & Morales, 2009; Wiktorowicz, 2018; Zaniboni Sarchielli, & Fraccaroli, 2010). Furthermore, people may be willing to postpone their retirement for such reasons as a good working environment, regulations and commitment, and work satisfaction (Chen et al., 2015; Duberley et al., 2014; Schreurs et al., 2011). The process of making a retirement decision includes the generation of retirement goals, such as the development of “optimization.” Individuals with positive perceptions of retirement set goals, plan their life after retirement, participate in meaningful activities, feel content about their health and life and benefit from good quality of life (Lee & Yeh, 2012; Noone et al., 2009), whereas those with negative perceptions of retirement tend to postpone retirement (Zaniboni et al., 2010).

The process of retirement adaptation includes adaptation before and after retirement (Lee & Yeh, 2012). Complex factors influence retirement adaptation, for instance, gender, age and physiology, health, financial condition, marital status and family relations, personal history, culture, and lifestyle (Kim & Moen, 2002; Topa et al., 2009; Zaniboni et al., 2010). Moreover, the availability of sufficient resources, knowledge and skills, and social support facilitate retirement decisions, preparations, and adaptation (Hsu, Chiang, & Chuang, 2015; Moffatt & Heaven, 2017).

Older adults must adapt to aging and life changes in order to develop well in their old age (Ogunbameru & Asa, 2008; Russell, 2011). This process refers to the “compensation” phase. Learning allows for the adaptation to career and life changes and promotes successful aging (Duay

& Bryan, 2008). By learning, older adults understand the importance of goal awareness, improve their ability to adapt, maintain physical health, psychological well-being, and active social participation and achieve successful aging (Fisher & Specht, 1999; Lee & Yeh, 2012). The process of compensation, which involves learning about and adapting to retirement transition, will help older adults to achieve successful aging.

Method

This study employed a qualitative research approach (Denzin & Lincoln, 2011) to examine retirement decisions, adaptation, and learning in baby boomers in Taiwan. Retired baby boomers recruited from students in older adult education institutions and community colleges in Taiwan via purposive sampling were interviewed. In total, 31 retired individuals (15 men and 16 women) were interviewed. With regard to their occupation before retirement, nine interviewees were teachers (kindergarten, elementary school, junior high school, and senior high school teachers), three interviewees were working in the public sector and 19 interviewees were working in the private sector (service, manufacturing, and science and technology). The participants were aged between 55 and 68, with their average age being 64 years. Their retirement age ranged between 45 and 66, with the average retirement age being 57 years.

Data were collected using semi-structured interviews (Roller & Lavrakas, 2015). The duration of each interview was 60–120 minutes. The interview questions were targeted at understanding participants' decisions regarding retirement timing, factors influencing retirement decisions, and adaptation and learning experiences after retirement. The interview venues included participants' learning institutions, homes, and the researchers' office. During each interview, questions were asked according to a certain outline, which was kept flexible in order to encourage free and exhaustive answers (Roller & Lavrakas, 2015). The interviews were audiotaped and transcripts of the interviews were prepared with the consent of the participants.

The interview data were analyzed using the constant comparative method (Glaser & Strauss, 1999). The interviewees' retirement decisions and adaptation experiences were analyzed in a systematic way. The researchers coded the transcripts to find similarities and identified the following categories: retirement timing, approaches to retirement decisions, and learning strategies after retirement. The implications of retirement decisions, adaptation, and learning in baby boomers in Taiwan were identified according to such categories as retirement timing, decision process, adaptation, and learning.

This study was supported by a grant from Taiwan's Ministry of Science and Technology. A research ethics review was not required for the implementation of this study. The study's objectives, implementation methods and process, interview questions, application of research results, and the rights of parties were explained in detail to each participant prior to their formal interviews. The interviewees' consent was taken voluntarily. Furthermore, each interviewee was assigned a code in order to conceal their identities. For example, 1M refers to the first interviewed male participant. All names, places, and titles appearing in the interviews were anonymized in order to protect the participants' identities.

Results

The results were divided into three categories, namely, the interviewees' decisions regarding retirement timing, the approaches to retirement decisions, and learning and adaptation after retirement.

Decisions regarding retirement timing

Expected retirement timing: participants had their first thoughts about the time of retirement when they started their careers or after working for a certain period.

Initially I was going to retire at the age of 55. (11F)

When I was young, I used to think that I would retire at the age of 60. (6M)

I estimated that I would be in civil service until the age of 65. (29M)

Gap: later or earlier than expected – participants planned certain time of retirement but began to hesitate as they approached retirement and retired earlier or later than expected.

I wanted to retire after 25 years of work but didn't think of what I could do after that. I was only 50 years old and decided to keep working. In the end, I retired at the age of 60. (26F)

According to the government's 55 project for government employees and teachers, the date of retirement was May 1 and not the end of a semester. The policy was too sudden. Students and I were not psychologically prepared. (12F)

Consideration of retirement timing is an early step in the conceptual framework of retirement transition (Atchley & Barusch, 2004; Topa et al., 2009; Wheatley, 2013). A gap is possible between the expected and actual time of retirement. Nevertheless, time is not the only factor considered in the decision regarding retirement timing. The decision is made under the influence of complex factors, which result in different approaches to retirement decisions.

Approaches to retirement decisions

Straightforward decision making: this approach to retirement decisions involves special factors, such as policies and health, which lead people to retire within a short period.

It so happened that there was a retirement plan that provided more money. (13M)

After I listened to a talk about depression at a hospital, I realized that I was suffering from it and I filed my retirement application right away. (19M)

Planned retirement: interviewees were considered to belong to this category if they made the decision to retire only after a considerable period of evaluation.

Further engagement in business would mean more investments with low return. (16M) During a meeting with my classmates I turned out to be the only one not to have retired yet. So I started planning my retirement. (11F)

Before my retirement, I was always thinking about what to do next when I was planning for it, that's why I had a smooth transition. I joined 6 different nonprofit organizations, became a lecturer at a family education center, and engaged in older adult education work. (2M)

Some participants were willing to pass on their work to younger generations.

We need to provide young people with opportunities and not deprive them of jobs. We can't keep up with the times anyway. (7F)

Economic independence of children and elderly and consensus between spouses promote the decision to plan retirement.

My two children are no longer financially dependent on me, so I didn't need to work hard anymore. (17M)

I didn't need to worry about finances, was self-sufficient, and didn't have to give money to my children. (21F)

My husband retired. If I retire, we would be able to do things together. (7F)

Hesitancy: Those who adopted this approach decided to retire gradually, after the accumulation of several negative factors.

I had to work hard in the freezer section at -25°C to support my family. I decided to retire after 25 years of such work. (24M)

I taught diligently but didn't have any sense of success because of my students' attitude toward learning. (4F)

After 30 years of doing the job, I lost interest and wanted to change my life. (18M)

Precipitated/involuntary retirement: This approach refers to cases in which people who were willing to continuing work were forced to retire due to policies, regulations, environmental factors, or family factors.

I was very happy and didn't plan to retire, but retirement at the age of 60 is compulsory in state-owned enterprises. (6M)

I heard that labor insurance will go bankrupt. The only alternative was to retire early! (23M)

Some participants decided to retire due to changes in work regulations, their reluctance to learn new technologies, or their intention to take care of family members.

The company was downsizing and I was deprived of my authority. So I just retired. (1M)

The school began computerization and it was difficult for old people like me. (7F)

My daughter-in-law just gave birth to my grandson and I wanted to help her take care of him. (11F)

My husband had a stroke and needed care. (21F)

Another important component of the conceptual framework of retirement transition is factors that influence retirement decisions (Atchley & Barusch, 2004; Topa et al., 2009; Wheatley, 2013). Complex factors influence retirement and include policies, work, family, and personal factors. Individuals choose to retire under the influence of complex factors and this process involves certain losses and gains, which corresponds to the “selection” concept proposed by Baltes and Baltes (1990). With regard to the participants, this process generated four approaches to retirement decisions, which were straightforward decision making, planned retirement, hesitancy, and precipitated/involuntary retirement.

Adaptation and learning after transition from work to retirement

Perceptions of retirement during decision-making

Awareness of health after retirement.

I thought – why not to retire while my physical health is good. I could do things I like. (13M)

I should take good care of my health, so as not to be a burden for my children. (29M) Attention to health means a longer life and more pension. (10F)

Relief from work-related pressure after retirement.

Work is physically demanding and there are many responsibilities. After you retire, you are responsible only for yourself and the pressure is not high. (19M)

There was work pressure before retirement and there was none afterwards. I could do more when I wanted to and less when I didn't. (7F)

Unwillingness and regret.

I was not willing to retire. When I retired, I felt that I was still young, able to work, and strong. (16M)

I had worked over 30 years in the business world, so I felt sentimental and a sense of unwillingness. (18M)

High adaptability.

I grew up facing hardships and could rely only on myself. (6M) I adapt easily and feel at home wherever I am. (7F)

Positive view toward life.

I face everything with a positive attitude. My wife is the same. We are content with our lives. (10F)

I am always full of faith in myself. I know I will live better than before. (22F)

Individuals may form positive or negative perceptions of retirement when they engage in the complex process of retirement decision-making (Lee & Yeh, 2012; Noone et al., 2009; Zaniboni et al., 2010). Development of perceptions of retirement can be described using the concept of “optimization”

proposed by Baltes and Baltes. During the transition process, interviewees discovered positive views toward retirement and found the strength to adapt. Moreover, negative perceptions of retirement encouraged participants to actively search for opportunities to adapt to life after retirement.

Adaptation and learning after retirement

Upon starting this fresh new chapter of their lives, retired people established new focus through active learning.

I have to realize that it is fun to study after retirement. (19M)

After retirement, I slowly got rid of work-related regrets and started life from a blank page. (13M)

There were various learning channels that helped participants adapt to aging and retirement.

My wife and I joined a university course on healthy aging, which was of very helpful. (3M)

When I saw a taichi school recruiting new students, I registered right away. (19M)

I read books and magazines about how to take good care of health and about life after retirement. I learned about ways to adjust and plan...I learned from other people's experience and asked for guidance in planning retirement. (15F)

The participants had learning experiences that they had not had before.

When I worked in the factory, I didn't know how to use a computer. I learned it after retirement. (19M)

I enrolled in community college courses right away when I retired. There is so much to learn and there is no pressure or assignments. (18M)

Learning helped the participants forget about negative past experiences and focus on good life experiences.

My past misfortunes became insignificant over time when I joined the new learning environment in a community college. (18M)

Going to college after retirement made me feel like I was a student again. I fulfilled my long lost dream of studying abroad. (8F)

Achieving values of successful aging via service learning

In Chinese families and society, upholding the spirit of service involves caring about people in the community, and participating in voluntary services, including learning, training and service activities related to volunteering.

Helping people is fun and you also gain something from it. (11F)

My mother-in-law is ill. I don't have anything else to worry about, so I can volunteer to help every day. (9F)

My husband and I are locals and find nothing wrong in helping the community. (4F)

Volunteering and learning.

The government promotes building of communities, which includes environmental protection, river inspection, volunteer groups, and care stations. (24M)

Building of a community raises many questions. You have to search for data and answers yourself. (28M)

Service learning as combination of knowledge, social connections, service, and value.

By doing volunteer work at the cultural bureau, I gain knowledge about culture. It is also a way to contribute to the society. (29M)

Volunteering is an opportunity for self-growth and meeting new friends. (6M)

When you use your knowledge to serve to people surrounding you, you live not just to live. You are affirmed. And you affirm yourself. (17M)

It's no use to earn a lot of money but contribute nothing to the society. All work I am doing now is meaningful. I am affirmed by society. (16M)

Retirement decision-making was followed by the retirement adaptation process (Atchley & Barusch, 2004; Topa et al., 2009; Wheatley, 2013), in which the interviewees gradually found focus, platform, and meaning of life. They eventually realized that participation in learning and service led to successful aging, which corresponded to the concept of compensation proposed by Baltes and Baltes.

Discussion

In past research on retirement, the process of retirement decision-making and adjustment was divided into considerations of retirement timing, factors influencing retirement, and retirement adjustments (Atchley & Barusch, 2004). This study explored baby boomers in Taiwan and indicated that retirement decisions and adjustment included awareness of retirement timing, approaches to decision, and retirement adjustment and learning. The occurrence of this process, as well as the transition and adjustment that were observed, were similar to those found in the model of selective optimization with compensation proposed by Baltes and Baltes (1990). However, with regard to baby boomers in Taiwan, retirement decision-making and adjustment involved many psychological and social factors. Moreover, adjustment and learning were found to play an important role in this process.

Past studies pointed out the complexity of factors that influence retirement (Topa et al., 2009; Wiktorowicz, 2018; Zaniboni et al., 2010) and the fact that individuals are faced with many changes (Hartlapp & Schmid, 2008; Havighurst, 1972). These changes are related to the choice of losses and gains (Baltes & Baltes, 1990). In this study, retirement was divided into straightforward retirement, planned retirement, hesitancy, and precipitated/involuntary retirement. Each approach led to the loss of the work role. Most participants also lost their main source of income. However, for some participants, these losses were accompanied by gains. As they chose to retire, they received a generous pension and could quit a job that affected their health due to the pressure, unhealthy conditions, or low sense of achievement associated with their work. Moreover, the baby boom generation in Taiwan experienced the move from poverty to prosperity (Wang & Lo, 2013). The interviewees belonging to this generation yearned for a sense of financial stability and took into account whether their children were independent. Participants, whose colleagues of the same age had been retiring, also began to plan their retirement. Retirement symbolized the handing down of professional experience, which is a positive rather than negative thing.

Losses and gains involved in retirement decision-making encourage individuals to search for optimization after retirement (Baltes & Baltes, 1990). This study indicated that the search for optimization is a gradual process affected by experience and learning. Baby boomers in Taiwan witnessed reforms in politics, economy, and education (Wang & Lo, 2013). They gradually broke away from the concept of raising children with the aim of providing for old age, which was common in Chinese society. The participants believed that retirement compensation included health, learning, and contribution. In addition to healthy life after retirement, health also referred to avoiding becoming a burden for children, as well as aiming for longer life and more pension. Although some participants initially felt unwilling to retire and regretted the decision, they eventually felt that, after retirement, they became more independent and could use the cultivated adaptability and optimism to access more learning and development opportunities.

The retirement adjustment process (Atchley & Barusch, 2004) involves a transition from optimization to compensation in successful aging (Baltes & Baltes, 1990). This study found that the process of optimization-compensation shift during retirement adjustment implied the overlapping of the two

states because some participants entered the compensation phase before confirming their specific optimization goals. They could think of learning and contribution without fully realizing their value. With regard to participation in learning, the participants sought out many learning channels after retirement. They could learn about adjustment to aging, while being able to undertake new learning activities. This corresponded to the results reported in past studies (Ogunbameru & Asa, 2008; Russell, 2011). Furthermore, learning helped some of the participants to forget about their feelings of regret with regard to retirement decisions, fulfil their dreams to study, and feel joy.

With regard to service learning, this study discovered that the participants' engagement in volunteer work was related to their experience. On one hand, Chinese society highlights the joy that one can derive from helping others. On the other hand, the baby boom generation benefited from better health, education, and human capital (Chen et al., 2015; Duberley et al., 2014), which made volunteer service an important compensation act during the participants' adjustment to retirement. When performing volunteer work, the participants learned how to serve other people and local community. Finally, they experienced successful aging through service learning. These results corresponded to those reported in past studies (Fisher & Specht, 1999; Lee & Yeh, 2012).

Conclusions

Baby boomers in Taiwan were born in poverty and raised in prosperity and witnessed reforms in educational and retirement-related policies. The participants' retirement decisions involved the consideration of retirement timing and included four approaches, namely, straightforward decision making, planned retirement, hesitancy, and precipitated/involuntary retirement. Each decision approach led to losses and gains and was affected by policies, work, family, and personal factors. The background of baby boomers provided them with high adaptability and motivation to learn and change. The retirement adaptation process presented goals related to health, learning, and contribution. Learning participation and service learning allowed the interviewed baby boomers to feel joy from learning, forget about their age, and maintain positive attitudes. The adaptation and learning processes of retired baby boomers as analyzed in this study add knowledge to the field of retirement adjustment and learning. The results of this study can provide workers engaged in older adult education with a reference for the formulation of policies and projects related to retirement transition and learning. Accordingly, we recommend that older adult educational program designers develop various activities for pre-retirees, such as voluntary work, community service, and learning activities, so as to help them to explore their interests and smoothly transition from work to retirement.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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